

Session 10: Isaac Blesses Jacob

Key Takeaways

- The scenes of Yaaqov and Esau asking blessing from their father are constructed to mirror each other: Yaaqov's deception and blessing reflects Esau's revelation of the truth and non-blessing.
- Yitskhaq introduces new vocabulary to the Eden blessing theme.
- Esau's non-blessing links him to previous non-chosen sons, Cain and Ishmael.

Yaaqov's Deception

18 And he said,
"My father."

And he said,
"Look, it's me.

Who are you, my son?"

19 And Yaaqov said to his father,

"I am Esau, your **firstborn (בכרד)** .

I have made just as you spoke to me.

Rise up, please, sit and **eat from my hunted-game,**
on account of which your being can bless (ברד) me."

20 And Yitskhaq said to his son,

"What is this, that you found so quickly, my son?"

And he said,

"Because Yahweh your Elohim caused it to happen before me."

21 And Yitskhaq said to Yaaqov,

"Come near, please, **so I can feel you** , my son,
if **you are my son Esau** or not."

22 **And Yaaqov came near** to Yitskhaq his father,

and he felt him ,

and he said,

"The voice is the voice of Yaaqov,
but **the hands are the hands of Esau.**"

23 And he did not recognize him,

because **his hands were like the hand of Esau** his brother, hairy.

And he blessed him.

24 And he said, **"You are my son, Esau?"**

And he said, "I am."

25 And he said,
"Come near to me,
so I can eat from the hunted-game, my son,
so that my being can bless you."
And he came near to him,
and he ate,
and he brought him wine,
and he drank.

26 And Yitskhaq his father said to him,
"Come near, please, and kiss me, my son."
27 And he came near and kissed him,
and he smelled the smell of his clothes,
and he blessed him and said,

Poem of Blessing

"Look, the smell of my son,
like of the smell of a field that Yahweh has blessed.
28 May Yahweh give you from the dew of the skies,
and from the fatness of the land,
and much grain and fresh wine.
29 May peoples serve you,
and may people groups bow down to you.
Be more mighty than your brother,
and may the sons of your mother bow down to you.
Those who curse you are cursed,
and those who bless you are blessed."

30 And it came about when Yitskhaq finished blessing Yaaqov,
and it was, indeed, just as he went outside from the face of Yitskhaq his father,
that Esau his brother came in from his hunting.

31 And he also made tasty-things,
and he brought to his father,
and he said to him,
"Let my father arise,
so he can eat from the hunted-game of his son,
on account of which your being may bless me."

32 And Yitskhaq his father said to him,
"Who are you?"
And he said,
"I am your son, your firstborn, Esau."

33 **And Yitskhaq trembled a great trembling, very much,**
and he said,

“Who, then, was it who **hunted game**

and brought to me,

and I ate it all before you came,

and I blessed him ...?

Indeed, **he will be the blessed one.**”

34 When Esau heard the words of his father,
then he cried a crying out, great and bitter, very much,
and he said to his father,

“**Bless me too**, my father!”

35 And he said,

“Your brother came with **deception (מרמה)**,

and he took **your blessing**.”

36 And he said,

“Isn’t he rightly called **‘Yaaqov’ (יעקב)**,

so that **he grabbed my heel (יעקבני)** these two times?!

He took **my firstborn-right**,

and look, now he has taken **my blessing**!”

And he said,

“Don’t you have a **blessing** reserved for me?”

37 **And Yitskhaq responded**

and he said to Esau,

“Look, I have set him as mightier than you,

and all his brothers I have given to him as servants,

and I supported him with grain and new wine.

So, for you, my son, what then can I do?”

38 And Esau said to his father,

“Is it just one **blessing** that you have, my father?

Bless me too, my father!”

And he lifted up his voice, and he wept.

39 **And Yitskhaq his father responded**,

and he said to him,

Poem of Non-Blessing

“Look, away from the fatness of the land,
there will be your dwelling,
and away from the dew of the skies above.

40 And by your sword you will live,
and you will serve your brother,
and it will come about when you wander free,
then you will break his yoke from upon your neck.”

The Poems of Blessing and Non-Blessing

The Eden blessing passed to Yaaqov through Yitskhaq is packed with hyperlinks to earlier statements of the blessing and to Eden symbolism.

The Blessing on Yaaqov: Genesis 27:27-29	The Blessings on Humanity and Avraham
²⁷Look, the smell of my son, like of the smell of a field that Yahweh has blessed. ²⁸May Yahweh give you from the dew of the skies, and from the fatness of the land, and much grain and fresh wine.	Edenic images of abundance: • “dew of the skies” = water that mysteriously appears and disappears, a gift of the skies • “fat of the land” = the most valuable produce • “grain and fresh wine” = the best produce
²⁹May peoples serve you, and may people groups bow down to you. Be more mighty than your brother, and may the sons of your mother bow down to you.	Gen. 1:28 Rule and Authority “And Elohim blessed them, and Elohim said to them, ‘Be fruitful and multiply, and fill the land, and subdue it; and rule over the fish of the sea ...”
Those who curse you are cursed, and those who bless you are blessed.	Gen. 12:2-3 “And I will make you a great nation, and I will bless you, and I will make your name great; and so you shall be a blessing; and I will bless those who bless you, and the one who curses you I will curse; and in you all the families of the earth will be blessed.”
<i>The Blessings on Yaaqov, Humanity, and Avraham. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>	

The first element of fertility and abundance echoes the strong Eden themes that have accompanied every mention of the blessing.

The final element speaks to God’s promise to protect Yaaqov from anyone who treats him as if he’s cursed instead of blessed. This repeats the promise God made to Abraham, and it recalls the moments when God took Abraham’s side (as in Genesis 14), even when he did not deserve it (as in Gen. 12:10-20).

The middle element, however, is new, and it's important to remember that Yitskhaq thinks he is speaking to Esau, not Yaaqov.

- The primacy and authority over one's brother is broadened to include authority over other people groups and all other siblings, which in this narrative includes only Esau.
- However, this novel element of the blessing is anticipating the final large movement of Genesis, about how two of Yaaqov's sons rise to prominence and receive the obedience and obeisance of their brothers and the nations.

Genesis 37:9-11 Instructor's Translation

⁹ And **Yoseph** dreamed again, another dream,
and he recounted it to his brothers,
and he said,
"Look, I dreamed a dream again,
and look, **the sun and the moon and eleven
stars were bowing down to me**."

¹⁰ And he recounted to his father and to his brothers,
and his father rebuked him,
and he said to him,
"What is this dream that you have dreamed?
**Will we really, I and your mother and your
brothers, come to bow down to you** on the
ground?!"

¹¹ And his brothers were jealous of him ...

Genesis 49:8-10 Instructor's Translation

⁸ **Yehudah**, as for you, **your brothers will praise you**.
Your hand will be on the neck of your enemies,
your father's sons will bow down to you.

⁹ A young lion is Yehudah
from the prey, my son, you have gone up.
He crouches, he lies down, like a lion,
and like a young lion, who will rouse him?

¹⁰ The scepter will not depart from Yehudah
nor the ruler's staff from between his feet,
unto when he comes to whom it belongs,
and the obedience of the peoples will belong to him.

The Poem of Non-Blessing

Yitskhaq gives to Esau an anti-version of the blessing he gave to Yaaqov. The language of the non-blessing contains hyperlinks that set Esau on analogy with Ishmael, Abraham's favored firstborn.

There are also allusions to the future of Esau's descendants, the Edomites, and their rebellion against the Israelites.

Analogies between Esau and Ishmael:

- Esau is told to “take up your gear, your quiver and your bow” ([Gen. 27:2](#)). // Ishmael will live in the wilderness by his bow ([Gen. 21:20](#)).
- “Is there only one blessing you have? Bless me also, my father.’ And Esau lifted his voice and wept.” ([Gen. 27:38](#)) // Hagar who seeks a blessing for her unchosen son “lifted her voice and she wept.” ([Gen. 21:16](#)) In Ishmael’s case, his mother weeps for him, but in Esau’s case, he has to weep for his own loss.
- Esau will live away from the fruitful land and will survive by his sword ([Gen. 27:39-40](#)). // Ishmael will live to the east of Yitskhaq and will live by his bow ([Gen. 16:12](#), [21:20](#)).

Gen. 27:39b-40

By your sword you will live,
and you will be a servant to your brother,
and it will be that when you rebel,
then you will tear away his yoke
from upon your neck.

1 Kings 11:14

Then the Lord raised up a *satan* to
Solomon, Hadad the Edomite; he was of
the royal seed in Edom.

2 Kings 8:20-22

²⁰ In [those] days **Edom revolted from
under the hand of Judah** , and made a
king over themselves ... ²² **So Edom
revolted against Judah to this day** .

Forward Hyperlinks to Future Rivalry of Edom and Israel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject
Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Reflection Question

What do Yitskhaq’s words and actions show us about his attitude toward the blessing he is invested with?